THE LIFE OF VIRAT KOHLI

From a Delhi Cricket Academy to the Summit of World Cricket

Early Life and Background

Virat Kohli was born on November 5, 1988, in Delhi, India, into a Punjabi Hindu family. His father, Prem Kohli, worked as a criminal lawyer, and his mother, Saroj Kohli, managed the household. Kohli grew up in the West Delhi neighborhood of Uttam Nagar alongside an elder brother, Vikas, and an elder sister, Bhawna. From a young age he showed an intense fascination with cricket, and at the age of nine he was enrolled at the West Delhi Cricket Academy, where coach Rajkumar Sharma began shaping his technique and temperament. Sharma would remain Kohli's mentor throughout his formative playing years.

Kohli's rise through the junior ranks was rapid. He captained the Delhi Under-15 team and later the Under-17 side, developing a reputation for aggressive strokeplay paired with disciplined technique. A defining moment of his early life came in December 2006, when his father passed away the night before a Ranji Trophy match. Kohli chose to bat the following morning regardless, scoring 90 runs to help Delhi avoid an innings defeat — an episode that was widely reported and became an early sign of the mental resilience that would come to define his career.

Rise Through the Junior and Domestic Ranks

Kohli's breakthrough on the national stage came in 2008, when he captained the Indian team that won the Under-19 Cricket World Cup in Malaysia. His performances in that tournament earned him a contract with the Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) franchise in the newly launched Indian Premier League, a relationship that has now spanned nearly two decades. He made his One Day International debut for India in August 2008 against Sri Lanka, and steadily worked his way into the senior national setup over the following two years.

Kohli went on to make his Test debut against the West Indies in June 2011, completing his transition across all three formats of international cricket within a few short years — a foundation that set up one of the most decorated careers the sport has seen.

Career Highlights and Records

Kohli built his reputation as one of the finest run-chasers and most consistent batters in modern cricket, particularly in the One Day International format. He succeeded Mahendra Singh Dhoni as India's Test captain in 2014 and later took over the ODI and T20I captaincy as well, going on to lead India in 68 Test matches — more than any other Indian captain — winning 40 of them and losing only 17. Under his leadership, India reached the final of the inaugural World Test Championship in 2021 and the final of the second cycle in 2023.

Across a 14-year Test career, Kohli scored 9,230 runs in 123 matches at an average of 46.85, including 30 centuries, making him the fourth-highest run-scorer in Indian Test history behind Sachin Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid, and Sunil Gavaskar. He retired from Test cricket in May 2025, shortly after Rohit Sharma's own Test retirement, describing the format's slower rhythms and quieter demands as something he would always look back on fondly.

In white-ball cricket Kohli's numbers are considered among the greatest of all time. He holds the record for the most ODI centuries in history, having gone on to pass 50 hundreds in the format, and he ranks among the leading run-scorers across ODIs and T20Is combined. He retired from T20 International cricket in June 2024, immediately after India won the T20 World Cup that year, wanting to give the next generation of Indian batters time to establish themselves before the following World Cup cycle. As of 2026 he remains an active ODI player and continues to represent Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the IPL, a franchise he has been associated with since the league's first season in 2008 and later captained to its first-ever title.

Playing Style and Reputation

Kohli is best known for his aggressive intent blended with technical precision, an unusually high fitness standard that reshaped expectations for Indian cricketers, and a hallmark ability to accelerate scoring while chasing targets under pressure. His on-field intensity and leadership by example — diving fielding efforts, animated celebrations, and vocal support for teammates — made him one of the sport's most recognizable competitors.

Personal Life and Legacy

Kohli married Bollywood actress Anushka Sharma in December 2017, following a relationship that began a few years earlier. The couple have two children together. Away from the field, Kohli has been vocal about fitness and lifestyle changes, crediting a shift toward disciplined training and diet around 2018 with extending the peak years of his career. He is also known for philanthropic work through the Virat Kohli Foundation, which supports underprivileged children, and for various commercial ventures spanning fashion, fitness, and food.

Kohli has received numerous honors over his career, including the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna, India's highest sporting honor, along with the Padma Shri and the Arjuna Award. He has been named ICC Cricketer of the Year multiple times and has repeatedly topped both the Test and ODI batting rankings during his peak years.

Legacy

By the time of his Test retirement, Kohli's combination of run-scoring consistency, captaincy success, and influence on fitness culture had already secured his place among the sport's modern greats. His record of more than 85 international centuries, his standing as India's most successful Test captain by win percentage, and his role in India's 2024 T20 World Cup title place him alongside the small group of players regarded as generational talents. As of 2026, with his ODI and IPL career still active, his final tally continues to grow, and the conversation around his ultimate place in cricket history remains ongoing.

Career Snapshot	
Born	November 5, 1988 — Delhi, India
Test debut	June 2011 vs West Indies
Test career	123 matches, 9,230 runs, 30 centuries (retired May 2025)
T20I career	Retired June 2024, after India's T20 World Cup win
ODI & IPL	Active as of 2026; RCB franchise player since 2008
Major honors	Khel Ratna, Padma Shri, Arjuna Award

Sources: ESPNcricinfo, Al Jazeera, and other cricket news coverage of Kohli's Test and T20I retirement announcements (2024–2025).